

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Integrate Health_Togo_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Integrate Health (formerly Hope Through Health)

Fellowship City

Kara

Fellowship Country

Togo

Fellowship Start Date

07/25/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

06/16/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Data Science Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Create novel data visualizations to represent the impact of various Integrate health projects. These visualizations are primarily created using Tableau

Improve the data processing capacity of the Monitoring and Evaluation Team, via the creation of new data processing flows, the improvement of existing data flows, and the creation of novel data quality checks. This work is primarily done using Alteryx.

Explore new areas of research, including new analysis of existing data, or employing new data science resources for novel research.

Contribute to ongoing Quality Improvement projects that tackle some of the most urgent or severe areas for improvement, both in Integrate Health data quality and health outcomes.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

When I arrived at the organization my supervisor had just begun a vacation, so I received an orientation from another colleague in the MEQI (monitoring, evaluation, and quality improvement) team. He helped me to get my laptop set up with existing software, went over several powerpoints on team structure, and gave me a folder with onboarding documents. I spent the first several weeks familiarising myself with the documents in the folder, and learning how to use the online resources outlined in the folder.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

I have more formal conversations with my supervisor about once or twice a week to outline my tasks for the week. On Mondays I send the entire Monitoring, Evaluation, and Quality Improvement team a list of my objectives for the week, and on Friday I send a list of what I achieved during the week.

I arrive at work between 8 am and 8:30 most mornings. I take about an hour to really be able to focus well in the mornings, so I try to do more straightforward tasks like check my email and plan for the day in that first hour. Afterwards I start on longer-term and more challenging projects on my computer and work on those projects until lunch. After lunch, I continue working on longer-term projects. I often hop between working on the actual project and documentation fairly freely. Then in the late afternoon when my energy levels decrease I will try to work on more short-term or repetitive projects, like the creation of certain excel sheets or small improvements or editing on data visualization projects.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40-45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I created a visualization summarizing the performance of Integrate Health over the past year. This visualization uses software called Tableau to summarize how both the regions and health centers administered by Integrate Health performed with regard to Integrate Health objectives. It shows the objectives for both 2022 and 2021, and will hopefully be able to be updated each year to include that year's objectives.

I created an automated process to document the number of days when medications were out of stock for Integrate Health. I received reports

listing the dates particular medications were out of stock. I then created a workflow using a software tool called Alteryx, that converts this list of dates into the overall percentage of medication availability at health centers, and the number of days in a month that health centers do not experience a stockout of important medication.

What is your organization's work culture like?

What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

My office environment has changed slightly since I arrived. For the first month and a half, I was working at a desk in a room with one other person. It was initially the colleague helping me with orientation, then my supervisor. Starting in mid-September, I moved into another office that has three other colleagues. It is approximately 25 by 15 feet, and is an outer office, meaning there are colleagues who work in other offices that have to pass through our workspace to enter and leave the building. Two of the three other colleagues will shortly move into another office, so there will be no more than two people in any office.

To whom do you report?

My primary supervisor is the MEQI (Monitoring, Evaluation, and Quality Improvement). Program Associate. I also check in with the Data Analyst as well as the Head of the MEQI team in Togo.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes it was. It gave us a chance to talk through what I was interested in working on throughout my fellowship year, and helped me get involved in the quality improvement projects with Integrate Health.

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

Create a system to reliably find outliers in all Integrate Health data.

Develop a subject-specific visualization for something like family planning that Integrate Health publishes on their public Dashboard.

Collaborate on a Quality Improvement Project run by Integrate Health, working to help identify a key area for quality improvement and suggest ways to better track performance accurately, or improve performance.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

Several new colleagues and I took on a day trip to a site called Naware two hours from my office in Kara. I got the chance to see how community health workers work with Integrate Health by monitoring the health of community members. I also had the chance to visit another IH site within approximately 30 minutes of Kara. I have not taken any overnight trips with IH.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel like I had the necessary technical expertise to quickly pick up the technological side of my job. Even though I didn't know the specific tools used by Integrate Health, I was able to learn them within a couple of weeks to a month. However, I am still adapting to working in a professional setting in another language, and am getting used to my first full-time professional experience.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket from Washington D.C. to Lomé Togo. It was a direct flight on Air Ethiopia. I have booked another return ticket from Lomé to Washington D.C. for December, and will be coming back to Lomé in early January. I am planning to book my final trip home next June using the same flight. The round-trip costs of the flight (to Togo in July and from Togo in June) totaled to \$1293.73.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I have a "visa de séjour" or a stay visa. Each visa lasts three months. However, the visa system is currently undergoing changes, and will likely be different for fellows in the upcoming year.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

When I arrived in country, I got a two-week visa at the airport. Now, I go to the local police station in Kara to renew the visa.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

I received my visa after arriving in my host country.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

My visa costs 65,000 CFA (approximately \$100 USD) every three months. However, I also paid approximately 40,000 CFA when arriving to the airport, for a 2 week visa to allow me to enter the country and

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

As of today, I have paid the visa costs. However, I am in the process of submitting expense reports to be reimbursed, and expect the costs to be covered by Integrate Health.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

The visa process is being digitized, so I suggest looking at the Togolese visa website for more information. Integrate Health also gives a document, "Know Before You Go" that has helpful information.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

Yellow Fever vaccination - \$220.69

COVID vaccination - Free

Typhoid vaccination- approximately \$120

Please note: I had obtained many 'travel vaccinations', including my rabies vaccine, before scheduling these vaccinations. If I remember correctly the rabies vaccine was approximately \$200 for each shot, with three shots needed for the vaccine to be fully effective.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

I arrived on July 21st after an overnight flight from the US. I stayed in Lomé at the Onomo Hotel, where I met up with Amina from the Princeton in Africa staff. After my first night in Lomé, an Integrate Health driver drove me to Kara, Togo and showed me to my room after introducing me to a few of the IH staff. I spent the first weekend getting to know Kara, and visiting the market. I then was introduced to all the IH staff in Kara during my first week, and began my onboarding procedure at work. I was also taken out to a lunch with the head of the MEQI team and my supervisor during the first week. It was a fairly smooth assimilation process, and I can't currently think of ways to streamline the process.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

The housing is provided and paid for by my host organization. I currently live in an apartment set up over where I work. However, in the next several months, Integrate Health has indicated that I may move into another apartment set up. This will also be provided and paid for by Integrate Health.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

I am living in an apartment with a bedroom and bathroom. There is also a kitchen that is entered by walking outdoors on a balcony, and is shared with the next door apartment. The kitchen has a gas stove top and oven, along with a small refrigerator. I am living above where I work, which at times can make it feel like I am always at work, but it also means I have a very short commute.

The city of Kara is a smaller city in the north of Togo (approximately 110,000 inhabitants). My apartment is in a developing district of the city. There are mostly dirt roads immediately around my apartment, but there are paved roads within a short walk. Many of my neighbors have adorable goats and chickens that wander around the corn fields by their houses. It's an interesting dichotomy since this area has many buildings that make it feel like a city, but crops or livestock often inhabit empty lots.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I do not typically travel between home and work, since I live just above my workspace. However, if I do end up commuting to work due to a housing change in the future, it will likely cost approximately 50 cents each way, and take approximately 10 minutes.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

I live in a small urban center (that is labeled by PiAf as a rural post) there are adequate stores and markets around for my daily needs. More complex requests, like new strings for my guitar, will need to be requested from Lomé. Lomé is a six to seven-hour drive to the south. This is also where the international airport is located. So far, I have also found health centers for adequate medical care in Kara.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather in my host country is quite warm and is currently changing from the wet season to the dry season. In mid-July when I arrived there were highs of approximately 80 degrees F and a normal daily temperature of approximately 75 F. It rained almost every day, often heavily. Currently, in late October, it has entered the dry season. There are highs of 98F and rain has decreased. It is now uncommon for it to rain during the week, and regular rain is not expected to resume until late April or early May.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

In work, most women wear nice blouses and dress pants, or dresses. Clothing styles are similar to work in the US, but not strictly “business casual,” and can often be a bit more fun. For example, I often wear long colorful skirts and a solid-print shirt or solid black pants and a patterned shirt. Generally, outside of work, I wear similar outfits but just my “less nice” outfits on days when I am going shopping or doing chores. Clothing styles for daily wear tend to be more conservative than in the US. While slightly above-the-knee dresses are fine to wear, most people do not wear shorts.

How have you been spending your free time?

I have been spending my free time playing soccer, going out for dinners, practicing guitar and playing video games. Every Saturday morning, Integrate health employees meet for soccer practice or soccer games, often starting at 6:30 am. I usually show up at approximately 8 am, because I’m not an early riser. Since I don’t play in the games, and just practice with the team, this hasn’t been a problem. I have also been going to dinner at several restaurants around Kara, including Kara Pizza, Kara Queen, and Place de la Victoire with work friends and some expat friends. I have been learning guitar and playing video games.

Additionally, I have noticed that churches often provide large social groups for their constituents. While I am not personally planning to attend church services regularly, if future fellows are interested, religious gatherings seem to provide a strong community network.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

My biggest tool in navigating my personal and social life has been to say yes to as many things as possible. When people ask me to hang out, go to soccer early on a Saturday morning, or go on a trip, I try to say yes. There have been a few times I was hesitant to do something because I was tired or feeling overwhelmed, but found that I usually felt better if I did it anyway. I don't think this style will work for everyone, but it has helped me to make friends and find activities to do. It also means people tend to ask me to join in on activities more, since I expressed interest in socializing in my first few months.

I'm a pretty quiet person when I'm in new environments, so it took a while for me to find social circles, but I now feel like I have a good group of people to hang out with, and usually have at least one or two scheduled social events each weekend (outside of Saturday soccer practice).

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I do feel that I live and work in safe areas. I have not had any negative experiences with safety.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I avoid traveling alone late at night. However, sometimes when it is dark (around 7 or 7:30 pm) I will walk five to ten minutes alone or get a motorcycle taxi to a gathering. I avoid carrying large amounts of money at any one time and store larger bills in a separate pouch in my bag so they aren't clearly visible when I am paying people. I am also sure to always wear a motorcycle helmet while getting taxi motorcycles. When I have to return home or travel late at night, I am sure to do so with work friends, or to at least have my friends help me to get a motorcycle taxi to take me home.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have not had any experiences with crime so far.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

I have heard from many colleagues that Kara is a quite safe area. They often make comparisons to Lomé and explain that Lomé has many more safety concerns than Kara. However, I have still gotten the general impression that women are not seen as safe alone late at night. I may only find this notable because I am from a rural community, so have never lived in a city. I have personally never felt unsafe.

I think fellows should stick to the areas that Integrate Health approves for their housing. I do not know about areas that should be avoided, since I have generally stayed in areas highly frequented by work colleagues, or other places I have already visited.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

Since VITALS is currently unavailable for me I can't tell, but I've been learning more French in a professional setting and been going outside of my comfort zone to make friendships with coworkers, which I believe were both goals I set before the orientation.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I have been struggling a bit to make friendships outside of work colleagues and ex-pats. However, I am happy to lean into friendships at work and think this is a good way to continue making more friends. I also feel a little stagnant at work sometimes, and like I am just doing busy work. However, I think this feeling will improve as I see more of the things I am working on wrap up.

As far as living arrangements, I am frustrated that sometimes the air conditioning can't be used at work (since it causes power to the building

to fail when there is a low electric current) and that water will sometimes not work for several days. Despite these mild frustrations, I think that my work and living environments are nice overall.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

I have been having some challenges in obtaining certain mental health medications that aren't available in Togo. However, I am currently working on finding a method to get them mailed.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I have called friends or family when I am feeling overwhelmed or lonely. I have also found a few circles of ex-pats who shared a similar experience. While I don't talk much about culture shock with them directly, it's nice to have one of my social circles be people undergoing a similar experience. Lastly, I was fairly quiet for the first several months of my fellowship, which helped me to interact with colleagues and friends in more intentional ways.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I have been surprised at how much my perception of the space I take up has changed in my first few months here. When I first arrived I felt very conspicuous and like I was always under scrutiny. While I still often feel this way, since I am visibly not Togolese, a lot of the anxiety or negative feelings that I initially experienced have died down, and I have begun to realize that even if I am often noticed, I am not often under intense or critical scrutiny. I didn't expect feeling perceived so much initially to bother me as much as it did, and I also didn't expect my confidence around that feeling of being perceived to change so much within the first several months.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

One small thing is that as it has entered the dry season it has gotten hotter at work. Sometimes there isn't enough power to run the air conditioning without cutting the power off, so then the office can get into the mid or high 90s. This makes it almost impossible for me to work, since I grew up in a pretty cold area, and heat makes me tired and irritable. The water also shuts off frequently during the hot season, and it makes washing dishes and personal hygiene more challenging. However, there are large plastic bins I have been able to fill with water to keep an adequate supply of water when it shuts off.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

I miss hot showers, singing in my university choir, and take-out Indian food from a specific restaurant near my home.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

There are more chances to socialize around soccer (which is my favorite sport).

The accessibility of fresh fruit and vegetables at the market.

I now know many of the people in the "nouveau marché" in Kara, and will ask how their families are doing. This more personal relationship with store vendors makes doing chores way more fun than I found it in the US.

How is your stipend being paid?

My stipend is being paid monthly to a US account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

My family is helping to cover the cost of the flights and vaccinations associated with this fellowship. Without that help, I would be unable to pursue this fellowship. I think this is a major weakness of the PiAf fellowship program. The stipends we are paid are not enough to cover our costs of travel, vaccinations, or other essential program components. While the stipends do cover the basic living costs once in the host country, this is not enough to make the fellowship financially realistic for many people who may want to do it.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$25.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$30.00	\$0.00	\$30.00	\$60.00	\$15.00	\$45.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$30.00	\$0.00	\$30.00	\$15.00	\$0.00	220.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I think the orientation had many helpful information sessions that prepared me to deal with the emotional ups and downs of arriving in a new country, as well as preparing me to operate in a professional setting. However, since I attended orientation virtually due to being COVID positive, I feel like I missed out on many of the social bonding experiences of the fellowship.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I can't think of anything

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

I would find it helpful to discuss how to have conversations about leaving your post since I have had many colleagues ask if I will decide to stay in Togo permanently. Having conversations on this topic has been challenging for me, since I like my colleagues and work environment a lot, but will almost certainly return to the US for medical school next year.